

with different processes in the company can sign into Twitter in this way (more on this later). Once you sign into Twitter, it is a good idea to add an image to the profile. It is irritating to follow a faceless Twitter account. The logo of the company works great, but an image of the individual tweeting works even better. The next step is to personalise the look of the Twitter page for the company. Go to http://twitter.com/account/profile_settings and click on Change background image. Twitter offers a whole range of background images to choose from, but it is better to create and use a background image from the company. It also makes sense to change the

SMART TIPS

Hashtags are a great way to generate and track buzz. Hashtags can be used within a post to refer to a particular event, or trend associated with the company. A good example is "#digitcarnival". Using hash tags allows those searching for the event to arrive at your feed, and for your company to track those talking about your event. Be careful though, overusing hash tags can kill your account.

background colours to match the logo of the company, or to use colours associated with the brand. Navigate to Change design colors, and a colour wheel appears for background, text, links, sidebar and sidebar border.

Twitter by default gives you a set of followers. Disable all of these, as they are not relevant to your business. You can follow people later on, as you figure out genuine accounts you are interested in, customers, employees or other accounts that make sense to your business, and add value to your stream. Now you have a Twitter account, and you are good to go. Now comes the difficult part, the long haul. Be prepared to take this seriously, and go through with it.

Tweeting for your business

Before you start tweeting, you have to understand the medium. This is not a place for harsh or brutal marketing practices. If say, you are an online store, it is a good idea to tweet links to products and offers, but you should offer something more. A Twitter feed that has only promotions, is not different from spam, and such accounts are disabled sooner or later. You have to get close and personal with your readers and customers. You have to add some sort of value to your feed – doing it all in 140 characters or less might seem a little daunting, but it has been done before. Tweet about the behind-the-scenes activity of the company, the immediate steps that the business is taking, and do it regularly. Discuss the general market scenario, the general direction of the market, and your opinions on a range of subjects. Keep in mind that the Twitter page is a brand-building exercise, not a tool for increasing the sales or generating traffic immediately. Imagine the organisation to be a person, or a single entity, who needs to update his friends about what he is upto – then proceed with the tweeting. If you are delegating the work of maintaining the Twitter account to an employee, or a number of employees, lay out a clear set of rules and guidelines.

This allows for coherence, and maintains a standard for the account. After a few months, it makes sense to have a long term plan in mind, to outline the direction of the account for some weeks or months into the future. When possible, offer something of extra value to those who follow your company on Twitter.

The nature of the tweets depends on the kind of business, and the scale of the operations. For companies or businesses that run out of blogs or web sites, Twitter is a tool that simply has to be used. The updates can vary from the status of the servers, to previews of upcoming content. Twitter can also nicely

accessorise your web page or blog, with a widget that syndicates recent tweets. Small or home businesses can keep an ear to the ground by using twitter, throw ideas around, let people know of upcoming plans and basically interact with a virtual community of their target market. SMBs are in a great position to exploit the real-time feedback that Twitter offers. This feedback is direct from the target market, and is not filtered in any way. Twitter makes it easy to pick up trends, and fads in the target market, and respond to them. Your constant updates makes customers feel that your company is active, alive and constantly working at doing a better job. Particularly at this level, Twitter is about enhancing the image of your company more than anything else.

Large businesses can divide their Twitter feeds in a number of ways. There can be a Twitter account for a particular product or a line of products. These accounts can offer promotional offers, discounts or freebies to participants or followers. This gets more people into the loop, more followers, and in the long run, more loyalty. Different processes within a company can update their status, and current direction within a company. A publication house can separate Twitter accounts for the editorial team, the PR team, and those who maintain the website. Such accounts, more than anything else familiarize the organization with the audience, and gives a face to the company. Alternatively, individual employees can append atcompany to their first names, and tweet about their personal activities, and involvement in the company. All these approaches are great for generating interest in the products of the company, and keeping the buzz about the company and its activities alive within the internet and out of it.

Tools for Twitter

There are a whole range of tools to help your business use Twitter better. *Tweetdeck* is a great tool for those who want to tap into Twitter to listen to the chatter. It allows you to follow a range of updates across social networking sites, including Facebook to have a look at what people are talking about you or your business. Just head over to <http://www.tweetdeck.com> and create a new account. Arrange the columns, sit back, and watch in real-time all the buzz your company is creating.



Head over to <http://search.twitter.com/> and key in your company name to find out what people are tweeting about your business.

TweetLater (www.tweetlater.com) is a great tool for those who have a plan for their Twitter accounts. You can key in Twitter updates with a time-delay. This also lets you stay active 24x7, giving the illusion that your business is always on. In case you have tight schedules, or leaving somewhere for a holiday, *TweetLater* is a great way to keep your account active. The best thing about *TweetLater* is that your use of it is in stealth, there is no way people will come to know if you are using it or not. The only thing missing is an automatic response to those who message you.

Now that you have your focus group, you can go ahead and study them. *Strawpoll* (<http://strawpollnow.com>) is a simple to use and free service that lets you setup polls. Embed these polls within tweets, and you have answers to those knotty questions that you want from your customers. 